

Evolution of the Tank

There were surprisingly few truly wrong turns taken along the road to developing the heavy armored fighting vehicle, and it followed a steady progression, incorporating innovations as and when they appeared, such as the rotating turret carrying the main armament. The first vehicle to be equipped in this way was the diminutive Renault FT-17, but from then on the arrangement was virtually ubiquitous—although tanks with multiple turrets appeared, too, like the Vickers A1E1 “Independent,” which had no

less than five. There was some uncertainty as to what form the main armament should take—some armies favored light vehicles armed with machine guns—but by the time World War II was underway all had settled on the format we see most commonly today (although some, like the French Char B1 and the American M3 Lee, retained multiple cannon), with a main gun capable of knocking out enemy vehicles, supplemented by machine guns to deal with softer targets.

